

Boston Tea Party

Examine how Patriots, British officials, tea merchants, and other colonists viewed taxation, resistance, and British authority.

? Historical challenge

On the night of December 16, 1773, colonists boarded three ships in Boston Harbor and threw 342 chests of East India Company tea into the water. Was this a bold defense of colonial rights, reckless destruction of property, or something in between? Investigate the sources, then map how four different groups saw the same event.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Massachusetts Historical Society – Boston Tea Party collection

PRIMARY SOURCE

Eyewitness primary sources, including John Rowe's diary entry for December 16, 1773 and a letter from John Andrews describing the tea being thrown overboard.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does an eyewitness describe what happened at Griffin's Wharf?
- What does the writer's word choice suggest about their point of view?

SOURCES 2

DPLA – The Boston Tea Party (primary source set)

PRIMARY SOURCE

A curated set of primary sources: a period map of Boston showing Griffin's Wharf, and documents about the tea and the colonists' response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Where were the ships docked, and why did location matter?
- Which groups appear in these sources — and which do not?

SOURCES 3

American Battlefield Trust – “Boston a Teapot Tonight!”

SECONDARY SOURCE

A secondary article giving background: the Tea Act of 1773, the meetings at Old South Meeting House, and Britain's response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did the Tea Act of 1773 anger many colonists even though it made tea cheaper?
- What did Britain do after the tea was destroyed?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in each group's card from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a card blank if the sources don't tell you.



Patriots (Sons of Liberty)

S1

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?



British Officials

S2

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

THE EVENT

Boston Tea Party

December 16, 1773

Griffin's Wharf, Boston



Tea Merchants

S3

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?



Other Colonists

S4

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Compare the voices

Where did perspectives overlap?

Where did they conflict?

Whose perspective is missing from the sources?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- With a partner, compare your cards. Where did you record the same thing? Where did your evidence differ?
- Which group's perspective was hardest to find in the sources? Why might that be?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was the destruction of the tea a justified defense of colonial rights, or did it go too far? Support your answer with evidence from at least two sources and at least two groups' perspectives.